

Psalms 94

The God of Vengeance

O Lord God, to whom vengeance belongeth, shew thyself
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O LORD God, to whom vengeance belongeth; O God, to whom vengeance belongeth, shew thyself.
- 2 Lift up thyself, thou judge of the earth: render a reward to the proud.
- 3 LORD, how long shall the wicked, how long shall the wicked triumph?
- 4 How long shall they utter and speak hard things? and all the workers of iniquity boast themselves?
- 5 They break in pieces thy people, O LORD, and afflict thine heritage.
- 6 They slay the widow and the stranger, and murder the fatherless.
- 7 Yet they say, The LORD shall not see, neither shall the God of Jacob regard it.
- 8 Understand, ye brutish among the people: and ye fools, when will ye be wise?
- 9 He that planted the ear, shall he not hear? he that formed the eye, shall he not see?
- 10 He that chastiseth the heathen, shall not he correct? he that teacheth man knowledge, shall not he know?
- 11 The LORD knoweth the thoughts of man, that they are vanity.
- 12 Blessed is the man whom thou chastenest, O LORD, and teachest him out of thy law;
- 13 That thou mayest give him rest from the days of adversity, until the pit be digged for the wicked.
- 14 For the LORD will not cast off his people, neither will he forsake his inheritance.
- 15 But judgment shall return unto righteousness: and all the upright in heart shall follow it.
- 16 Who will rise up for me against the evildoers? or who will stand up for me against the workers of iniquity?
- 17 Unless the LORD had been my help, my soul had almost dwelt in silence.
- 18 When I said, My foot slippeth; thy mercy, O LORD, held me up.
- 19 In the multitude of my thoughts within me thy comforts delight my soul.
- 20 Shall the throne of iniquity have fellowship with thee, which frameth mischief by a law?
- 21 They gather themselves together against the soul of the righteous, and condemn the innocent blood.
- 22 But the LORD is my defence; and my God is the rock of my refuge.
- 23 And he shall bring upon them their own iniquity, and shall cut them off in their own wickedness; yea, the LORD our God shall cut them off.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 94 is a plea for justice against arrogant, violent oppressors who exploit the vulnerable while assuming God either does not see or will not act. Its turning point is theological rather than circumstantial: the psalmist reasons that the God who gave eyes and ears to humanity must Himself see and hear, and that discipline from Him, however painful, is proof of relationship rather than abandonment. Henry reads it as a corrective for anyone tempted to think unpunished wickedness means unnoticed wickedness; MacArthur-style notes highlight verse 14's assurance—God will not cast off His people—as the psalm's load-bearing promise.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The opening cry addresses God directly by a title rarely used so plainly—the God to whom vengeance belongs—asking Him to show Himself, to lift up Himself against the proud. The complaint is stated as a question: Lord, how long shall the wicked, specifically the wicked, continue to triumph?

Verse 4-7

The oppressors are described in their own words and actions: they speak arrogantly, all who work iniquity boast, they break in pieces God's own people and afflict His heritage, they slay the widow and the stranger and murder the fatherless. Worse than the violence itself is their reasoning—they say the Lord shall not see, the God of Jacob will not even take notice.

Verse 8-11

The psalmist answers that reasoning head-on, addressing the 'brutish' and foolish among the people directly: will the one who planted the ear not hear, the one who formed the eye not see? The one who instructs nations and teaches man knowledge surely knows the thoughts of man already—futile thoughts included.

Verse 12-15

A turn toward blessing: happy is the one whom God chastens and teaches from His law, giving rest from days of adversity while a pit is being dug for the wicked. The Lord will not cast off His people nor forsake His inheritance; judgment will in time return to righteousness, and all the upright in heart will follow it.

Verse 16-19

Personal testimony follows: who would have risen up for me against evildoers, had the Lord not been my help? When he said his foot was slipping, God's mercy held him up; in the multitude of anxious thoughts within him, God's comforts brought delight to his soul—inner turmoil met directly by inner comfort, not merely by outward rescue.

Verse 20-23

The psalm closes with confidence that a throne of iniquity can have no real fellowship with God, however it frames its injustice as law. Though the righteous may be gathered against and condemned as innocent blood, the Lord is a defense, a rock of refuge, and will bring the wicked's own iniquity back upon them, cutting them off in it—justice delayed, but not denied.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Unpunished wickedness is not unnoticed wickedness; the same God who designed human eyes and ears to perceive certainly perceives every act of oppression and every self-justifying lie that assumes He does not. Discipline from God, far from signaling abandonment, is evidence of ongoing relationship, and His people can trust that a throne built on injustice has no lasting fellowship with Him, whatever temporary power it holds.

Application for life today.

When cruelty or exploitation seems to go unanswered, resist the quiet lie that God has not noticed; bring the specific injustice to Him as directly as this psalm does, naming both the wrong and your desire for Him to act. If you are currently under God's discipline, let verses 12–13 reframe it as evidence of relationship and teaching rather than rejection. In your own 'multitude of thoughts' (v. 19), notice where anxious rumination needs to be met not just by information but by God's actual comfort, sought deliberately in prayer.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

- 1.** Where do you see the lie of verse 7—'the Lord will not see'—quietly shaping how injustice is tolerated around you or within you?
- 2.** How does reframing a current hardship as God's chastening and teaching (vv. 12–13), rather than His absence, change how you respond to it?
- 3.** In your own 'multitude of thoughts' (v. 19), what specific worry needs to be met by deliberately seeking God's comfort rather than more analysis?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).